

Building on a Vision

L&T'S CHAIRMAN EMERITUS A. M. NAIK HAS BUILT A MAMMOTH ENTERPRISE THAT IS BUILDING A NEW INDIA, FROM ITS METRO RAIL SYSTEMS TO THE RAM TEMPLE

BY **KRISHNA GOPALAN**



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HOW DOES ONE describe A. M. Naik? Feisty, determined, Indian at heart, ambitious, or a proud Larsen & Toubro (L&T) employee? Maybe it's all of this and more. It is by no means easy to capture such an illustrious journey in a book. Perhaps, the title of the latest book on him, *The Man Who Built Tomorrow*, comes closest to the truth.

Whatever it is, one has to just look around and see the magnitude of L&T's work to understand Naik's contribution. From metro rail systems across many an Indian city and abroad, to the 182-metre Statue of Unity in Gujarat, the Atal Setu bridge in Mumbai, the Ram Temple in Ayodhya, the howitzer gun, nuclear reactors, the successful foray into the information technology sector, and water treatment plants, L&T's presence is palpable across the length and breadth of the country. That long list calls for a grand vision and remarkable execution.

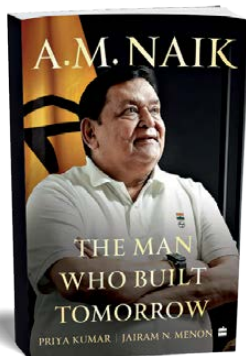
The Man Who Built Tomorrow captures key moments in Naik's life and the lessons that come with them. By any yardstick, it is a fascinating career for someone who joined L&T as a junior engineer in

1965 to take charge of the corner office. One common thread is his nationalism and how he wears it unabashedly on his sleeve. The book mentions an instance from last year, when Naik was at IIM Ahmedabad to address graduating students. In his inimitable fashion, he did not hold back when it came to driving home a firm message. "Some of you may have already firmed up your plans to accept lucrative offers from overseas. I would urge you to pause and reflect on what you are

doing. We all have a larger obligation towards our homeland, the nation that has made us what we are. You are the brightest talents of our country and have the responsibility of helping India realise its vision." He did not stop there and went on to say that there were enough opportunities in India to challenge their capabilities and fulfil aspirations. "You will get a sense of satisfaction you will never get anywhere abroad."

Naik has left the company in the hands of those he mentored. Today, he is the conglomerate's Chairman Emeritus, but his contributions over nearly six decades will be felt for many years to come. He truly transformed L&T for a new India. **BT**

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A.M. NAIK: THE MAN WHO BUILT TOMORROW

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PUBLISHER
HARPERBUSINESS

PAGES 256; PRICE ₹699